

Network Infrastructure & pfSense Configuration

Overview

This document details the complete network infrastructure setup using **pfSense** as the core firewall and routing platform, implementing enterprise-grade **VLAN segmentation** with a **TP-Link TL-SG108E managed switch**. The architecture provides isolated network segments for different security functions while maintaining centralized control and monitoring.

Hardware Architecture

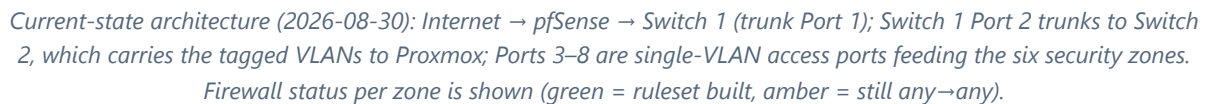
Core Components

- **pfSense Firewall**: Dedicated desktop machine with 2 NICs
- **TP-Link TL-SG108E (Switch 1)**: 8-Port Gigabit Smart Managed Switch; Port 1 trunk to pfSense, Port 2 trunk to Switch 2
- **Switch 2 (secondary switch)**: uplinked from Switch 1 Port 2; passes the tagged VLANs through to Proxmox
- **Primary Laptop**: Administrative workstation (192.168.10.3)
- **Proxmox VE Host**: Bare-metal hypervisor connected to Switch 2 (192.168.10.6), receiving all tagged VLANs
- **Vault Desktop**: Dedicated machine for HashiCorp Vault on Port 6, VLAN 40 (192.168.40.2 , awaiting configuration)
- **Windows Server 2025 Host**: Dedicated hardware on Port 7, VLAN 50, domain controller at 192.168.50.2 (connected via USB-to-Ethernet adapter)

Physical Topology



Visual Overview



For a detailed interactive view with hover effects and clickable elements, see the [Interactive Network Architecture Diagram](#).

- **pfSense Firewall:** Enterprise-grade routing and security with 2 NICs
- **** Managed Switch**:** TP-Link TL-SG108E with 8 ports supporting VLAN tagging
- **VLAN Segmentation:** 6 isolated network zones for different security functions
- **Security Model:** Default-deny firewall with explicit rules for each VLAN
- **Hybrid NAT:** Controlled outbound access for all network segments

pfSense Configuration

Interface Configuration

Base Interface Changes

- **Default LAN (ue0):** Changed from 192.168.1.1 to 192.168.99.1
- **Isolation Applied:** No DHCP, blocked traffic for security
- **VLAN Parent:** All VLANs created under interface ue0
- **WAN Interface:** Maintains connection to upstream router

Interface Assignment Summary

Interface	Type	Purpose	IP Address
WAN	Physical	Internet connectivity	DHCP from ISP
LAN (ue0)	Physical	VLAN parent interface	192.168.99.1 (isolated)
VLAN 10	Virtual	Management access	192.168.10.1
VLAN 20	Virtual	BlueTeam security	192.168.20.1
VLAN 30	Virtual	RedTeam operations	192.168.30.1
VLAN 40	Virtual	DevOps pipeline	192.168.40.1
VLAN 50	Virtual	EnterpriseLAN	192.168.50.1
VLAN 60	Virtual	Monitoring stack	192.168.60.1

All six VLAN interfaces are **802.1Q tagged sub-interfaces of the single physical LAN NIC ue0**. This is the pfSense half of a *router-on-a-stick* design: one cable to the switch trunk carries every VLAN, and pfSense does the routing between them.

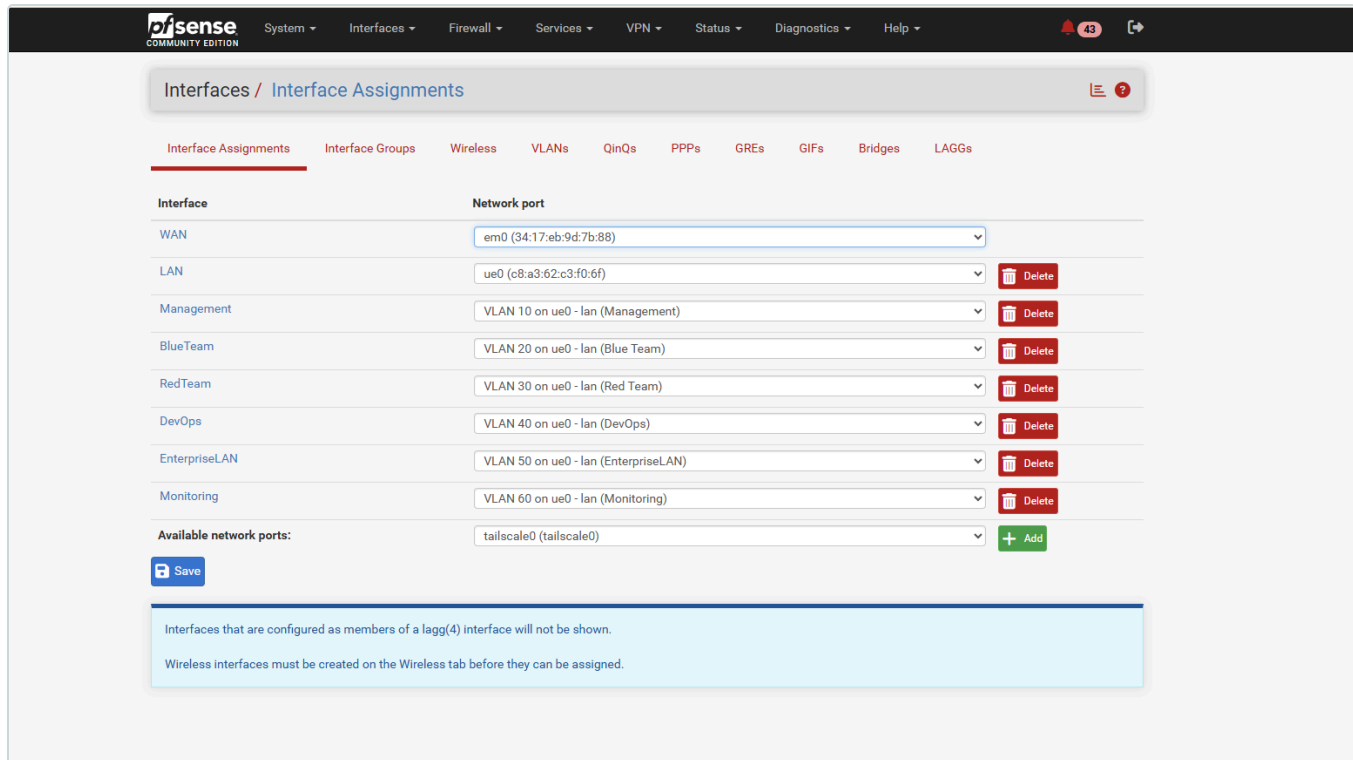


Figure 1.1: Interfaces → Assignments. Each VLAN (Management 10 ... Monitoring 60) is a tagged sub-interface of the parent `ue0`, alongside WAN (`em0`) and the isolated LAN. This is the pfSense half of the 802.1Q trunk; the switch half appears in Figures 1.4–1.5.

Each VLAN interface has a static gateway IP and **no upstream gateway** (it is a local network, not an internet uplink), so pfSense treats it as a routed LAN segment:

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Interfaces / Management (ue0.10)

General Configuration

Enable
☒ Enable interface

Description
Management
Enter a description (name) for the interface here.

IPv4 Configuration Type
Static IPv4

IPv6 Configuration Type
None

MAC Address
XXXXXXXXXX
The MAC address of a VLAN interface must be set on its parent interface

MTU
If this field is blank, the adapter's default MTU will be used. This is typically 1500 bytes but can vary in some circumstances.

MSS
If a value is entered in this field, then MSS clamping for TCP connections to the value entered above minus 40 for IPv4 (TCP/IPv4 header size) and minus 60 for IPv6 (TCP/IPv6 header size) will be in effect.

Speed and Duplex
Default (no preference, typically autoselect)
Explicitly set speed and duplex mode for this interface.
WARNING: MUST be set to autoselect (automatically negotiate speed) unless the port this interface connects to has its speed and duplex forced.

Static IPv4 Configuration

IPv4 Address
192.168.10.1
/ 24

IPv4 Upstream gateway
None
Add a new gateway
If this interface is an Internet connection, select an existing Gateway from the list or add a new one using the "Add" button.
On local area network interfaces the upstream gateway should be "none".
Selecting an upstream gateway causes the firewall to treat this interface as a WAN type interface.
Gateways can be managed by clicking here.

Reserved Networks

Block private networks and loopback addresses
☐
Blocks traffic from IP addresses that are reserved for private networks per RFC 1918 (10/8, 172.16/12, 192.168/16) and unique local addresses per RFC 4193 (fc00::/7) as well as loopback addresses (127/8). This option should generally be turned on, unless this network interface resides in such a private address space, too.

Block bogon networks
☐
Blocks traffic from reserved IP addresses (but not RFC 1918) or not yet assigned by IANA. Bogons are prefixes that should never appear in the Internet routing table, and so should not appear as the source address in any packets received.
This option should only be used on external interfaces (WANs), it is not necessary on local interfaces and it can potentially block required local traffic.
Note: The update frequency can be changed under System > Advanced, Firewall & NAT settings.

Figure 1.2: Example interface detail (Management, ue0.10): static IPv4 192.168.10.1/24 , upstream gateway set to None because inter-VLAN routing is handled internally by pfSense. The same pattern is applied to VLANs 20–60.

VLAN & Subnet Architecture

Design Philosophy

The network implements **VLAN-based segmentation** where each VLAN represents a separate logical security zone. This approach ensures:

- **Layer 2 isolation** between different environments
- **Granular firewall control** via pfSense rules
- **Enhanced monitoring** and policy enforcement
- **Clear separation** between Blue Team and Red Team activities

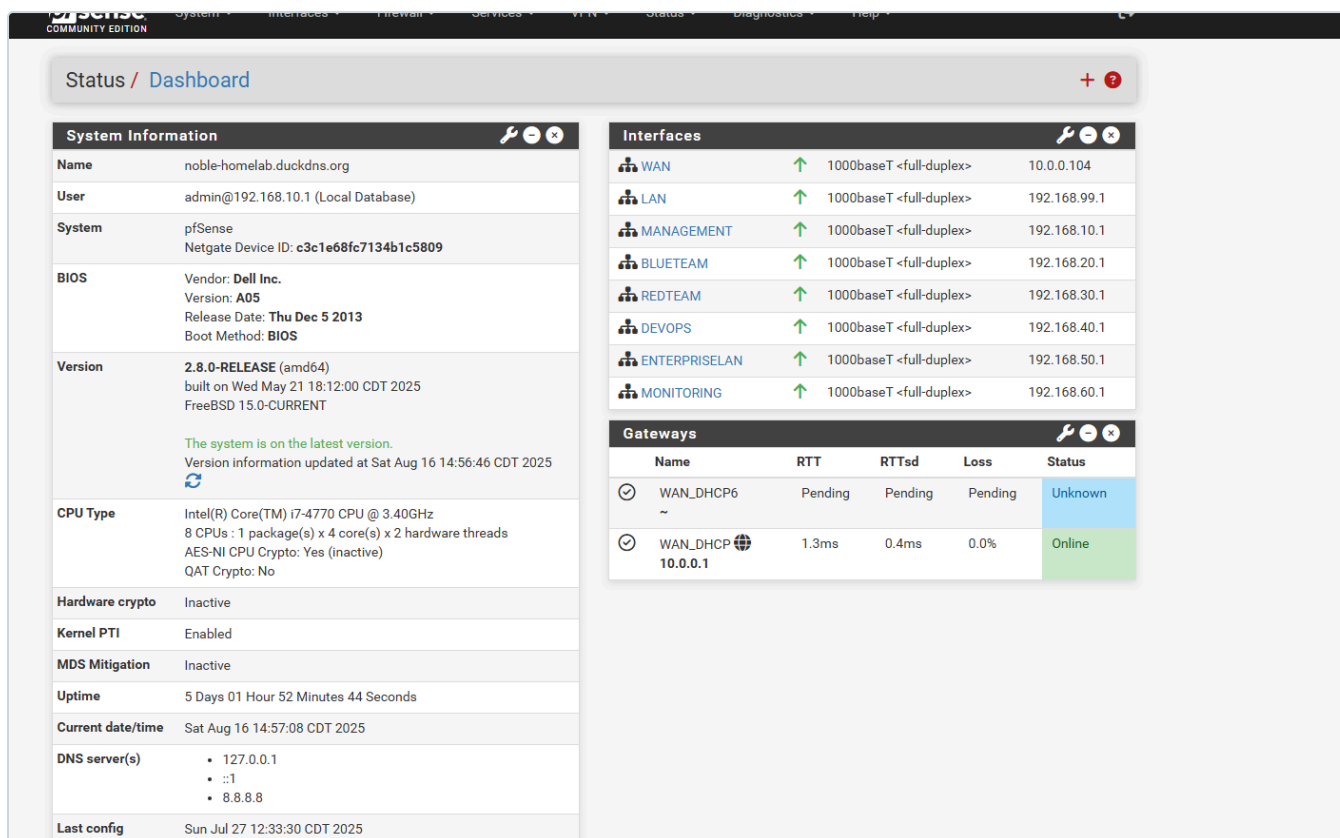


Figure 1.3: pfSense dashboard: all six VLAN interfaces up, each with its gateway IP (192.168.10.1 ... 192.168.60.1), plus the WAN uplink. This is the live confirmation that every segment specified below is active and routing.

Complete VLAN Specification

Interface	VLAN ID	Subnet	Gateway	Description
Management	10	192.168.10.0/24	192.168.10.1	Administrative access to pfSense Web UI and management systems. Restricted to trusted admin devices only.
BlueTeam	20	192.168.20.0/24	192.168.20.1	Security monitoring infrastructure including Wazuh SIEM, ELK stack, IDS sensors, and defense tools.
RedTeam	30	192.168.30.0/24	192.168.30.1	Isolated environment for attack simulation, penetration testing, and offensive security experiments.
DevOps	40	192.168.40.0/24	192.168.40.1	CI/CD infrastructure, build servers, deployment automation, and DevSecOps toolchain.
EnterpriseLAN	50	192.168.50.0/24	192.168.50.1	Simulated business services including internal DNS, web applications, and corporate server infrastructure.
Monitoring	60	192.168.60.0/24	192.168.60.1	Dedicated observability stack hosting Prometheus, Grafana, Loki, and out-of-band monitoring systems.

Network Segmentation Benefits

- **Enhanced Security:** Layer 2 isolation with pfSense firewall control
- **Clear Visibility:** Each team/function has dedicated network space
- **Safe Testing:** Attack simulations contained within RedTeam VLAN
- **Monitoring:** Centralized observability without network interference

DHCP Configuration Strategy

IP Address Allocation Plan

Each VLAN subnet uses a structured IP allocation to prevent conflicts and ensure predictable addressing:

- **Static Range:** .2 through .49 (48 addresses for servers/infrastructure)
- **DHCP Pool:** .50 through .100 (51 addresses for dynamic assignment)
- **Reserved:** .101 through .254 (154 addresses for future expansion)

DHCP Scope Configuration

Example: Management VLAN (192.168.10.0/24)

- **Static Assignments:** 192.168.10.2 – 192.168.10.49
- **DHCP Dynamic Pool:** 192.168.10.50 – 192.168.10.100
- **Future Use:** 192.168.10.101 – 192.168.10.254

This pattern is replicated across all VLANs for consistency.

DHCP Implementation Evidence

Management VLAN DHCP Configuration

Not secure https://192.168.10.1/services_dhcp.php?if=opt1

Apps | YOUTUBE | GOOGLE STUFFS | CLOUD | LEARN | SCHOOLS | CYBERSECURITY | MY WEBMAIL FRO... | (11) Top 5 Must-Try... | Imported | Use best practices t...

pfSense COMMUNITY EDITION System Interfaces Firewall Services VPN Status Diagnostics Help 14

Services / DHCP Server / MANAGEMENT

Settings LAN MANAGEMENT BLUETEAM REDTEAM DEVOPS ENTERPRISELAN MONITORING

General Settings

DHCP Backend	Kea DHCP
Enable	☒ Enable DHCP server on MANAGEMENT interface
Deny Unknown Clients	Allow all clients When set to Allow all clients, any DHCP client will get an IP address within this scope/range on this interface. If set to Allow known clients from any interface, any DHCP client with a MAC address listed in a static mapping on any scope(s)/interface(s) will get an IP address. If set to Allow known clients from only this interface, only MAC addresses listed in static mappings on this interface will get an IP address within this scope/range.
Ignore Client Identifiers	☐ Do not record a unique identifier (UID) in client lease data if present in the client DHCP request This option may be useful when a client can dual boot using different client identifiers but the same hardware (MAC) address. Note that the resulting server behavior violates the official DHCP specification.
DNS Registration	Track server Optionally overrides the DHCP server default DNS registration policy to force a specific policy.
Early DNS Registration	Track server Optionally overrides the DHCP server default early DNS registration policy to force a specific policy.

Primary Address Pool

Subnet	192.168.10.0/24	
Subnet Range	192.168.10.1 - 192.168.10.254	
Address Pool Range	192.168.10.50 From	192.168.10.100 To
The specified range for this pool must not be within the range configured on any other address pool for this interface.		
Additional Pools	+ Add Address Pool If additional pools of addresses are needed inside of this subnet outside the above range, they may be specified here.	

Server Options

BlueTeam VLAN DHCP Configuration

Not secure https://192.168.10.1/services_dhcp.php?if=opt2

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Services / DHCP Server / BLUETEAM

Settings LAN MANAGEMENT BLUETEAM REDTEAM DEVOPS ENTERPRISELAN MONITORING

General Settings

DHCP Backend	Kea DHCP
Enable	☒ Enable DHCP server on BLUETEAM interface
Deny Unknown Clients	Allow all clients When set to Allow all clients, any DHCP client will get an IP address within this scope/range on this interface. If set to Allow known clients from any interface, any DHCP client with a MAC address listed in a static mapping on any scope(s)/interface(s) will get an IP address. If set to Allow known clients from only this interface, only MAC addresses listed in static mappings on this interface will get an IP address within this scope/range.
Ignore Client Identifiers	☐ Do not record a unique identifier (UID) in client lease data if present in the client DHCP request This option may be useful when a client can dual boot using different client identifiers but the same hardware (MAC) address. Note that the resulting server behavior violates the official DHCP specification.
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Primary Address Pool

Subnet	192.168.20.0/24	
Subnet Range	192.168.20.1 - 192.168.20.254	
Address Pool Range	192.168.20.50 From	192.168.20.100 To
The specified range for this pool must not be within the range configured on any other address pool for this interface.		
Additional Pools	+ Add Address Pool If additional pools of addresses are needed inside of this subnet outside the above range, they may be specified here.	

Server Options

Strategic Benefits

- ✔ **Predictable Infrastructure:** Critical systems use static IPs
- ✔ **Conflict Prevention:** Clear separation between static and dynamic ranges
- ✔ **Scalability:** Significant room for future growth
- ✔ **Consistency:** Identical pattern across all VLANs

Firewall Rules & Access Control

Security Model

pfSense implements a **default-deny** security model where all traffic is blocked unless explicitly allowed. Each VLAN has customized firewall rules based on its security requirements and operational needs.

Management VLAN (VLAN 10) Rules

Action	Protocol	Source	Destination	Purpose
Allow	ICMP	VLAN 10 Subnet	Any	Network troubleshooting and connectivity testing
Allow	TCP/UDP	VLAN 10 Subnet	This Firewall	Access to pfSense Web UI (HTTPS)
Allow	UDP	VLAN 10 Subnet	Any (Port 53)	DNS resolution services
Allow	Any	VLAN 10 Subnet	Any	Full internet access for administrative tasks

Management VLAN Firewall Implementation

Firewall / Rules / MANAGEMENT

FloatingWANLANMANAGEMENTBLUETEAMREDTEAMDEVOPSENTERPRISELANMONITORING

Rules (Drag to Change Order)

	States	Protocol	Source	Port	Destination	Port	Gateway	Queue	Schedule	Description	Actions
☐	✓ 14/10.44 GiB	IPv4 UDP	MANAGEMENT subnets	*	*	*	*	none		Allow DNS lookups	   
☐	✓ 0/77 KiB	IPv4 ICMP	MANAGEMENT subnets	*	*	*	*	none		Allow ping to pfSense from VLAN 10	   
☐	✓ 0/0 B	IPv4 TCP	*	*	This Firewall (self)	*	*	none		Allow Web UI from VLAN 10	   
☐	✓ 59/11.58 GiB	IPv4 TCP	MANAGEMENT subnets	*	*	*	*	none		Allow general outbound traffic	   

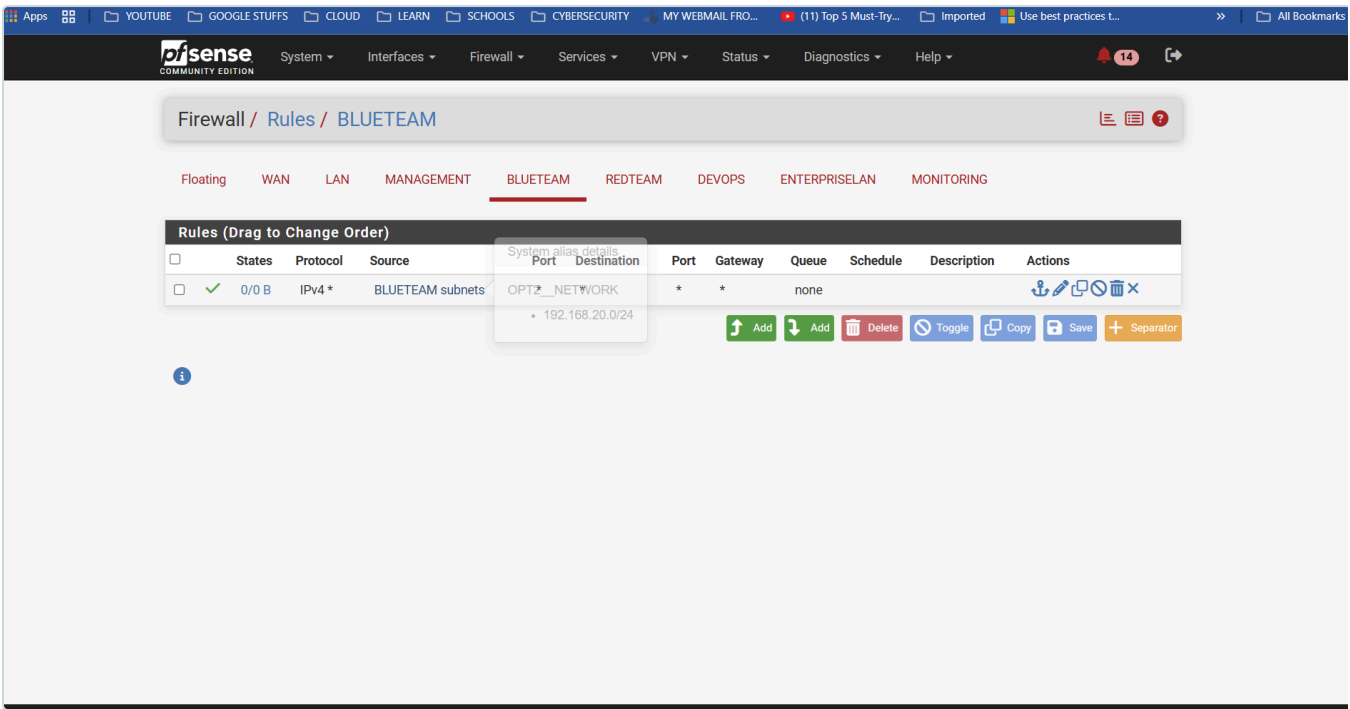
 Add  Add  Delete  Toggle  Copy  Save  Separator

Other VLANs Security Rules

For **BlueTeam, RedTeam, DevOps, EnterpriseLAN, and Monitoring** VLANs:

Action	Protocol	Source	Destination	Purpose
Allow	Any	VLAN [X] Subnet	Any	Full internet access for operational requirements

Additional VLANs Firewall Configuration



Firewall Rule Strategy

- **Management VLAN:** Most permissive with administrative access
- **Operational VLANs:** Internet access with potential for future restrictions
- **Inter-VLAN Communication:** Controlled by specific rules as needed
- **Default Behavior:** All traffic denied unless explicitly permitted

Active Directory Firewall Aliases

Why aliases

A pfSense **alias** is a named list of hosts or ports that a firewall rule can reference by name. Instead of eight separate rules ("allow TCP 53 to the DC", "allow TCP 88 to the DC", ...) there is one rule that reads "allow AD_TCP to SRV1_DC ". Rules become self-describing, and when a port needs adding or removing it is changed once in the alias rather than in every rule that uses it.

Active Directory is not a single service. A domain member relies on a bundle of protocols (DNS, Kerberos, LDAP, SMB, RPC, NTP) that all terminate on the domain controller. Blocking any one of them produces confusing half-working behaviour (can join but cannot log on, logs on but Group Policy fails, password

changes error out). The aliases below group those protocols by role so that access can be granted precisely.

Alias inventory

Alias	Type	Contents	Purpose
SRV1_DC	Host	192.168.50.2	Windows Server 2025 domain controller dc01.ad.biira.online (alias name predates the host rename SRV1→DC01)
AD_TCP	Ports	53, 88, 135, 389, 445, 464, 636, 3268	TCP ports a domain member needs on the DC
AD_UDP	Ports	53, 88, 123, 389, 464	UDP ports a domain member needs on the DC
AD_RPC_DYNAMIC	Ports	49152:65535	RPC dynamic high-port range (see note)
MGMT_TCP	Ports	3389, 5985, 5986	Remote administration only: RDP and WinRM

AD_TCP : domain-membership TCP ports

Port	Protocol	What it does
53	DNS	Clients look up SRV records such as _ldap._tcp.ad.biira.online to locate the DC. TCP carries large answers and zone transfers; UDP carries ordinary queries.
88	Kerberos	The core AD authentication protocol. Every logon and every access to a network resource obtains a Kerberos ticket from the DC.
135	RPC endpoint mapper	The "directory assistance" for Microsoft RPC. A client asks 135 which dynamic port a given service is listening on, then connects there. Required for domain join, Group Policy and remote management.
389	LDAP	Reading and writing the directory: user lookups, group membership, computer objects.
445	SMB	File sharing. Clients pull Group Policy objects and logon scripts from the DC's SYSVOL and NETLOGON shares.
464	Kerberos password change	Used when a user changes a password or a computer rotates its machine-account password (every 30 days by default).
636	LDAPS	LDAP over TLS. Not required by Windows itself, but Linux tooling, HashiCorp Vault's LDAP auth method and Wazuh integrations prefer it. Included so those work without a later rule change.
3268	Global Catalog	A read-only, forest-wide index of the directory. Logon uses it to resolve universal group membership; directory-aware applications search it.

AD_UDP : domain-membership UDP ports

Port	Protocol	What it does
53	DNS	Everyday name resolution.
88	Kerberos	Kerberos tries UDP first for small requests and falls back to TCP.
123	NTP	Domain members sync their clocks to the DC. Kerberos rejects tickets when clocks differ by more than 5 minutes, so this port is silently critical.
389	LDAP ping	A lightweight "are you a DC for my site?" probe that clients send while locating a domain controller.
464	Kerberos password change	UDP variant of the password-change service.

AD_RPC_DYNAMIC : why it is separate

After a client asks port 135 where a service lives, the DC answers with a random port in the **49152 to 65535** range and the client connects there. Domain join, Group Policy processing and AD replication all depend on this. Because the range is large it is kept in its own alias and granted only from tightly scoped sources (Management VLAN to `SRV1_DC`), never bundled into `AD_TCP` where it might be handed out more broadly.

MGMT_TCP : why RDP and WinRM are not in AD_TCP

RDP (3389) and WinRM (5985 plain, 5986 TLS) are for *administering* the server, not for *being a member* of its domain. Keeping them separate means that granting a client VLAN "`AD_TCP` to `SRV1_DC`" for domain membership never accidentally grants remote console or automation access as well. `MGMT_TCP` is granted only from the Management VLAN (administrator laptop and the Ansible controller).

Outbound NAT Configuration

NAT Implementation Approach

To enable proper internet connectivity for all VLAN segments, pfSense uses **Hybrid Outbound NAT** mode, providing explicit control over network address translation while maintaining automatic rule generation for standard interfaces.

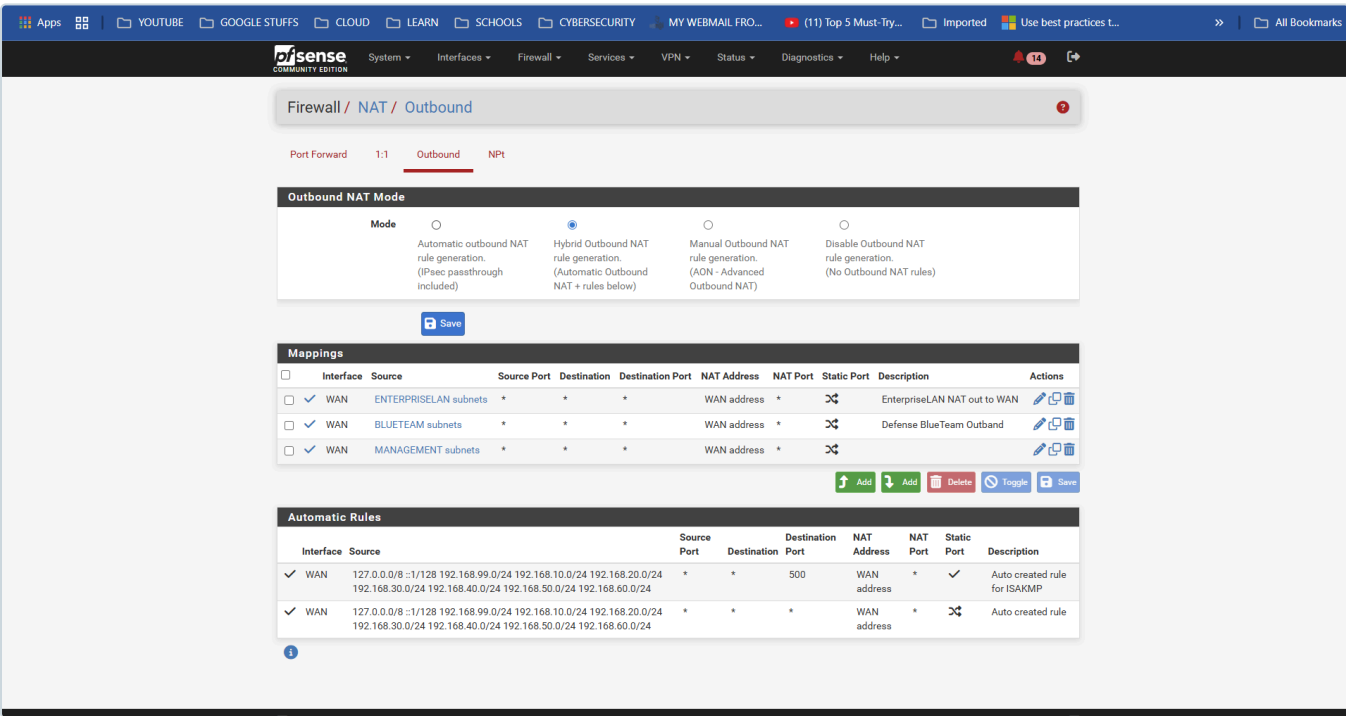
Configuration Method

1. **Mode Selection:** Firewall > NAT > Outbound
2. **Mode Change:** Switched to "**Hybrid Outbound NAT rule generation**"
3. **Rule Creation:** Manual rules defined for each VLAN subnet

NAT Rule Specification

VLAN Name	Source Subnet	Translation Target	Status
Management	192.168.10.0/24	WAN Interface	Active
BlueTeam	192.168.20.0/24	WAN Interface	Active
RedTeam	192.168.30.0/24	WAN Interface	Active
DevOps	192.168.40.0/24	WAN Interface	Active
EnterpriseLAN	192.168.50.0/24	WAN Interface	Active
Monitoring	192.168.60.0/24	WAN Interface	Active

Hybrid Outbound NAT Configuration



Hybrid NAT Advantages

- Flexibility:** Manual control over VLAN-specific NAT behavior
- Compatibility:** Retains pfSense default rules for other interfaces
- Scalability:** Easy to modify or restrict specific VLANs
- Visibility:** Clear understanding of NAT translations

Switch Port Configuration

TP-Link TL-SG108E Port Mapping

The managed switch provides VLAN segmentation through strategic port assignments, supporting both trunk and access port configurations.

Port 1	Trunk (Tagged)	All VLANs: 10,20,30,40,50,60	pfSense ue0 interface connection
Port 2	Trunk (Tagged)	All VLANs: 10,20,30,40,50,60	Trunk to Switch 2 (secondary switch). Proxmox VE (192.168.10.6) connects via Switch 2 and receives the tagged VLANs for multi-VLAN VM hosting
Port 3	Access (Untagged)	VLAN 10 Only	Management VLAN direct access
Port 4	Access (Untagged)	VLAN 20 Only	BlueTeam VLAN direct access
Port 5	Access (Untagged)	VLAN 30 Only	RedTeam VLAN direct access
Port 6	Access (Untagged)	VLAN 40 Only	DevOps VLAN, dedicated HashiCorp Vault desktop (192.168.40.2 , awaiting configuration)
Port 7	Access (Untagged)	VLAN 50 Only	EnterpriseLAN VLAN, Windows Server 2025 domain controller (192.168.50.2 , via USB-to-Ethernet adapter)
Port 8	Access (Untagged)	VLAN 60 Only	Monitoring VLAN direct access

Switch Port Configuration Evidence

The switch enforces the same VLAN scheme from the Layer 2 side. Two settings define it: **802.1Q VLAN membership** (which ports carry which VLANs, and whether tagged or untagged) and the **PVID** (the VLAN an *untagged* frame is placed into as it enters a port).

Port Configuration Strategy

- **Trunk Ports (1-2):** Carry all tagged VLAN traffic, Port 1 uplinks pfSense; Port 2 trunks to Switch 2, which carries the tagged VLANs on to the Proxmox VE VLAN-aware bridge
- **Access Ports (3-8):** Provide direct, untagged access to specific VLANs
- **Device Placement:** End devices automatically assigned to appropriate VLAN
- **Scalability:** Additional devices easily added to any VLAN segment

Security Implementation

Network Security Measures

- **LAN Interface Isolation:** Original `ue0` interface secured with no DHCP or routing
- **Administrative Access Control:** All pfSense GUI access restricted to Management VLAN
- **Inter-VLAN Security:** No default communication between VLANs
- **Controlled Connectivity:** ICMP enabled only for troubleshooting purposes

Access Control Summary

- **pfSense Management:** Only accessible via `http://192.168.10.1` on VLAN 10
- **VLAN Isolation:** Each VLAN operates independently unless rules permit interaction
- **Firewall Protection:** All traffic subject to pfSense security rules
- **Default Deny:** Implicit denial of all traffic not explicitly permitted

Implementation Challenges & Solutions

Key Issues Resolved

Issue 1: Lost Administrative Access

Problem: Disabling original LAN interface caused loss of pfSense access

Solution: Assigned fallback IP and implemented blocking instead of disabling

Lesson: Always maintain administrative access during network changes

Issue 2: Windows Client Connectivity

Problem: Windows clients unable to ping across VLANs

Solution: Enabled ICMP Echo in pfSense firewall rules

Resolution: Network troubleshooting capabilities restored

Issue 3: Internal vs External Connectivity

Problem: External connectivity worked (8.8.8.8) but internal failed

Root Cause: Local firewall rules blocking internal VLAN communication

Fix: Adjusted firewall rules for appropriate inter-VLAN access

Issue 4: GUI Access Verification

Problem: Uncertainty about pfSense management access

Verification: Confirmed GUI accessible via `http://192.168.10.1` on VLAN 10

Result: Administrative access properly secured and functional

Implementation Verification

Network Connectivity Tests

- **VLAN Gateway Access:** All VLANs can reach their respective gateways
- **Internet Connectivity:** Outbound NAT functional for all segments
- **DNS Resolution:** Name resolution working across all VLANs
- **Administrative Access:** pfSense GUI accessible from Management VLAN

Security Verification

- **VLAN Isolation:** Confirmed separation between network segments
- **Firewall Rules:** All configured rules operational and effective
- **Access Controls:** Administrative functions properly restricted
- **NAT Translation:** Proper address translation for internet access

Next Phase Integration

Prepared Infrastructure

The network foundation now supports: - **Security Services:** SIEM deployment in BlueTeam VLAN - **Monitoring Systems:** Observability stack in Monitoring VLAN - **Automation Platforms:** Ansible controller in Management VLAN - **Testing Environments:** Red Team tools in isolated RedTeam VLAN

Expansion Capabilities

- Additional VLANs easily configured
- Scalable DHCP and firewall rule management
- Support for complex inter-VLAN communication requirements
- Ready for enterprise service deployment

Network Infrastructure Status: Complete and Operational

Next Phase: [Security Monitoring Stack Deployment](#)